

PASSION, PRIDE AND JOY Members of the Indian women's cricket team hold aloft the ICC World Cup trophy at the DY Patil stadium in Navi Mumbai, Nov. 2

GETTY IMAGES

Cricket's New Sheroes

› **As champions in 2025, the Indian women's cricket team won Rs 40 crore from the ICC and Rs 51 cr from the BCCI**

› **The team's first World Cup final in 2005 fetched each player Rs 8,000**

› **Next target for Harmanpreet & Co: the T20 World Cup in June-July in England & Wales**

For long, the women in blue lived under the imposing shadow of the men's national cricket team. International matches were few, visibility negligible. Ever since their ODI World Cup final appearance in 2017 and the start of the Women's Premier League in 2023, they were on the verge of breaking through to the other side—recognition, adulation and big bucks. It was the sheer tenacity, chutzpah and cricketing calibre with which Harmanpreet Kaur's girls passed through the mirror that sealed them a spot in Indian cricket's hall of fame. At the finish line, on November 2, 2025, the team was crowned world ODI champions. No one had foreseen this eventuality after the team suffered three consecutive losses in the group stages of a home tournament. But after being written off, they defeated New Zealand in a must-win tie, following it up with a victory over seven-time world champions Australia in the semis. Then, outplaying South Africa in the finals, the team gave a fitting reply to detractors. "Trolls wanted Indian women to cook. So they cooked," said a widely shared comment on social media.

And what a delectable feast it was, involving a galaxy of chefs—pacer Kranti Goud, just five months old in the national side, vexed opening batters with her swing; Richa Ghosh was dependable with the gloves and a pistol with the bat; vice captain Smriti Mandhana played crucial knocks, like the century against New Zealand; Jemimah Rodrigues overcame the setback of being dropped for a match to play the innings of the tournament against Australia; Deepti Sharma blazed a trail of consistency (215 runs and 22 wickets) all through to emerge player of the tournament; Shafali Verma, called up at the nth hour, saved her best—with both bat (87) and ball (two wickets)—for the finals, and there was the inspirational Kaur, who exorcised ghosts of past failures to script the sweetest redemption song.

The 'sheroics' at DY Patil Stadium in Navi Mumbai didn't come out of the blue. All the new poster girls have a lifetime of winning against the odds behind them. Their back stories are uniformly inspiring and emblematic of a developing India. Family members didn't just have to ignore sexist taunts to let girls pursue their dreams. The moment was also built on a foundation of sacrifices—Deepti's brother forsook his own career to practise with her; Kranti's mother sold off her jewellery so she could travel for tournaments; Radha Yadav's sister Sonee even gave up the sport as the family could afford to support only one. Most of them are also from India's villages and small towns. That's how life-changing sports can be for young girls if they are given a level-playing field.

The sheroics of the women's cricket team was built on sacrifices by family members and battles fought by past generations of women cricketers

It has taken nearly five decades for the women's game in India to experience this euphoric high. Kaur's side is aware of battles that their precursors fought. For this young band who don't shy away from talking about mental struggles in the face of adversity, share their bonhomie on social media, even get matching tattoos, the journey to raise the profile of the women's game is a continuing endeavour. May they breach more boundaries. ■